

CHARLES HARLESS

Software Engineering Manager

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PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

Software Engineering Manager with 15+ years of experience delivering mission-critical platforms for Disney, Amazon, and NBCUniversal. Launched Disney Movies Anywhere to 20M+ users, led global supply chain engineering at Amazon Prime Video, and guided distributed teams building enterprise media systems at scale. Translated ambiguous business priorities into clear engineering roadmaps, reduced operational drag through rigorous prioritization, and grew engineers into senior contributors. Equally comfortable in the architecture review and the 1:1.

CAREER HIGHLIGHTS

- Launched Disney Movies Anywhere with 3.5M mobile downloads and 20M+ users within the first month
- Reduced engineering backlog by 75% in 30 days at Brightcove through a prioritization framework
- Improved deployment frequency by 20% via CI/CD pipeline modernization and automated testing
- Decreased application latency by 25% through distributed systems architecture improvements
- Drove 40% improvement in team engagement through structured mentorship and performance coaching
- Reduced AWS cloud operating costs by 15% through infrastructure sizing and architectural guidance

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Senior Software Engineering Manager (Independent Consulting)

Jan 2024 – Present

Thinking Bear Productions – Engineering Consulting – Los Angeles, CA (remote)

- Advise engineering organizations across 5 clients on distributed systems design and Agile
- Increased engineering velocity by 20% through backlog management and sprint discipline
- Identified and implemented AWS infrastructure optimizations reducing operating costs by 15%
- Authored LinkedIn articles on technical architecture and engineering leadership

Computer Science Instructor

Aug 2015 – Dec 2019 | Aug 2023 – Present

UCLA Extension – Computer Science – Los Angeles, CA (on-site 2015–2019; remote 2023–present)

- Taught Java Programming, Data Structures, and Web Applications across 20 sections and 200+ students; sustained a 4.7 / 5.0 instructor rating throughout both tenures

Software Engineering Manager

Jan 2023 – Jun 2023

Brightcove – Digital Media Engineering – Boston, MA (remote)

- Led 2 teams of 15 engineers building media management applications for 2,500+ global customers
- Reduced application latency by 25% and improved system stability through architecture refactoring
- Eliminated 75% of engineering backlog within 30 days by introducing a prioritization framework
- Increased team engagement scores by 40% through 1:1s, feedback, and individualized growth planning
- *Role eliminated in company-wide reduction in force, June 2023*

Software Development Manager

Jan 2021 – Jun 2022

Amazon Prime Video – Global Supply Chain Engineering – Culver City, CA (hybrid)

- Led engineering development of services managing 800+ streaming content licensing contracts
- Improved engineering team velocity by 15% through a data-driven prioritization framework
- Defined a 3-year engineering roadmap aligning technical investment with long-range business strategy
- Hired 2 engineers and promoted 2 engineers, expanding team capability and providing career pathways
- Coordinated a security remediation rollout across 2,000+ applications, completing in under 1 week
- *Role concluded following org restructure, June 2022*

Staff Software Engineer / Engineering Lead

Apr 2016 – Dec 2020

NBCUniversal – Workplace Collaboration Engineering – Universal City, CA (on-site)

- Served as technical lead and team manager for 5 engineers developing internal mobile applications used by 23,000+ employees globally
- Redesigned push notification system, increasing engagement by 10% while reducing opt-outs by 20%

Principal Software Engineer

May 2015 – Mar 2016

Sage Software – Innovation Labs – Irvine, CA (hybrid)

- Led development of a cross-platform mobile framework adopted across 5 enterprise products
- Authored engineering standards improving code quality and long-term maintainability by 15%

Staff Software Engineer

Nov 2011 – Apr 2015

Walt Disney Studios – Distribution Technology & Technology Innovation Group – Burbank, CA (on-site)

- Launched Disney Movies Anywhere streaming platform achieving 20M+ registered users and 3.5M mobile downloads within the first month
- Deployed high-availability streaming media infrastructure maintaining 99.9% uptime for 4TB of content using adaptive bitrate (HLS/DASH) and DRM technologies
- Prototyped a Beacon-based indoor navigation system improving visitor wayfinding in buildings by 25%
- Designed a blockchain-based digital entitlement delivery reducing projected delivery costs by 20%

Senior Software Engineer

Dec 2005 – Oct 2011

Walt Disney Parks & Resorts – Architecture & Operations Teams – Glendale, CA (on-site)

- Led engineering for 12 award-winning consumer-facing websites; established LAMP architecture standards improving development speed and deployment reliability by 30%

EDUCATION & CERTIFICATIONS

- **Master of Science in Computer Science** – University of California, Los Angeles
- **Bachelor of Science in Computer Science** – University of Alabama
- **Certified ScrumMaster** & Certified Scrum Product Owner – Scrum Alliance
- Generative AI Fundamentals Certificate – Databricks
- AWS Cloud Practitioner Essentials – Amazon Web Services

TECHNICAL SKILLS

- **Cloud Platforms:** AWS (Lambda, ECS, S3, API Gateway), Docker, CloudFormation
- **Streaming Media:** HLS, DASH, DRM (Widevine & FairPlay), CDN architecture
- **Software Development:** Java, Spring, Node.js, JavaScript, TypeScript, React
- **Architecture:** Microservices, distributed systems, REST APIs, CI/CD, DevOps
- **Developer Tools:** GitHub, Jenkins, SQL, NoSQL